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SLIS 6330: Collection Development

A Selection and Deselection Manifesto

1. A library collection is never finished.
As S.R. Ranganathan reminds us, "a library is a growing organism." Like any healthy organism, our collection grows, adapts, and changes alongside our community. Our goal, as our *Collection Development Policy* states, is to provide outstanding, personalized service while protecting intellectual freedom and supporting lifelong learning.

2. Selection and deselection are the same process.
Deselection is simply reverse selection. The librarians who choose materials are also the people best equipped to evaluate whether those materials still deserve a place on the shelf. Professional judgment matters. So does looking critically at the reviews we rely on. We should be aware of coded language, stereotypes, and microaggressions in professional reviews and intentionally seek materials that represent diverse voices and culturally responsive perspectives.

3. More is not always better.
A carefully curated "boutique" collection often serves patrons better than a warehouse of everything. Overcrowded shelves make browsing more difficult and hide great books among outdated or little-used ones. Weeding improves discoverability while protecting the library's credibility. A patron who finds an astronomy book that still lists Pluto as a planet may begin to question the reliability of the rest of the collection.

4. The digital age changes collection development.
Open Educational Resources (OERs) and freely available digital collections such as Project Gutenberg and the Library of Congress make some little-used print materials available elsewhere, allowing us to use limited shelf space more intentionally. At the same time, we need to be attentive to our ebook and digital collection subscriptions, which should be held to the same standards of currency and relevance as print collections.

5. Professional standards guide our decisions.
The MUSTIE and WORST criteria provide well-established frameworks for evaluating print and audiovisual materials. Low circulation over three to five years is one important indicator, but we should always consider other factors like condition, accuracy, uniqueness, and community need.

6. Better data leads to better collection decisions.
Circulation statistics are valuable, but they don't tell the whole story. Each branch should have a Branch Mascot library card to check out materials left on tables and carts before immediately checking them back in at the end of each day. This would capture meaningful in-house use that is otherwise invisible in circulation statistics. The idea came from our Spanish Language Collection Librarian who observed that many Spanish-speaking patrons use materials inside the library without borrowing them, possibly because of concerns about replacement fees or different cultural expectations about how libraries operate.

7. Transparency builds trust.
Explaining why materials are weeded and removed helps avoid misconceptions about censorship or mismanagement of taxpayer funding. Being open and upfront with patrons that weeded materials in good condition go to the Friends of the Library for used book sales, and materials in poor condition are recycled, could help them feel better about this necessary process.

A clean shelf waiting for the right book serves our community better than a crowded shelf with outdated information. After all, a library is a growing organism.

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